

Contractor UAS Compliance Checklist

NDAA Section 848, Blue UAS training requirements, and the fielding-to-operator gap most primes miss at delivery.

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About This Checklist

For program managers, BD leads, and contract teams at defense primes and system integrators. Covers the regulatory environment, the training gap that appears at platform delivery, and the tools to close it before the support calls start.

THE FIELDING PROBLEM

Platforms get delivered. Operators don't get trained. The receiving unit calls the prime for support. The prime sends a contractor on-site. That cycle repeats for years — driven entirely by a training gap that could be closed in 10–15 days before delivery.

Section 1: NDAA Section 848 Quick Reference

Section 848 of the FY2020 NDAA restricts DoD from procuring UAS from covered entities (primarily Chinese manufacturers including DJI and Autel). Understanding the implications for both hardware and training is essential.

✓ Covered Entities

Huawei, ZTE, Hikvision, Dahua, Hytera — and UAS manufacturers with components from these suppliers. DJI and Autel remain restricted for DoD procurement.

✓ What It Affects for Primes

Any UAS platform delivered to DoD must be NDAA-compliant. Training programs using restricted platforms may not meet acceptance criteria at delivery.

✓ Training Implication

If your training program uses DJI or other restricted hardware, operators are learning on systems that won't match what they'll actually deploy. This creates both a compliance gap and a capability gap.

✓ Blue UAS Program

DIU's Blue UAS program lists DoD-approved NDAA-compliant platforms. Training on Blue UAS-listed platforms (or architecturally equivalent systems) is the most defensible approach for prime contractors.

✓ **FFA Compliance**

Forge and Flight Academy trains exclusively on NDAA-compliant platforms. Parent company Forge & Flight Labs is a U.S. manufacturer of DoD-compatible UAS systems.

Section 2: Blue UAS Training Requirements Checklist

Use before your delivery milestone. Check off each item when complete.

- ☐ Platform is on the current DIU Blue UAS approved list (or equivalent NDAA-compliant alternative)
- ☐ Training curriculum covers the specific platform's flight controller and autopilot architecture
- ☐ Operators trained on field repair and component replacement specific to the delivered platform
- ☐ EW awareness training completed — operators can recognize and respond to jamming conditions
- ☐ FAA Part 107 certification obtained or verified for all operators (if operating in civilian airspace)
- ☐ Proficiency documented with objective, defensible ratings — not just attendance records
- ☐ At least one internal instructor certified to replicate training without contractor support
- ☐ Training records retained and available for contract acceptance review
- ☐ Curriculum updated to reflect current platform firmware and operational procedures
- ☐ Assessment services completed if contract requires third-party capability verification

Section 3: The Fielding-to-Operator Gap

Platform delivery and operator readiness are treated as separate workstreams — and operator readiness almost always loses.

Stage	What Typically Happens	What Should Happen
Pre-Delivery	No operator training scoped. Focus is on platform acceptance testing.	Operator training program scoped and contracted alongside platform delivery.
At Delivery	Platform handed over. Unit has no trained operators. Contractor provides a demo.	First operator cohort trained. One internal instructor certified.
30 Days Post	Support calls begin. Prime sends on-site support. Cost clock starts.	Unit operating independently. Internal instructor replicating training.
12 Months Post	Recurring contractor on-site support with no defined end date.	Second cohort trained internally. No contractor involvement.

Section 4: Train-the-Trainer ROI

FFF-402 (FPV Master Trainer Certification) certifies an internal instructor who can deliver FFF-401-equivalent training without contractor involvement indefinitely.

ROI EXAMPLE

Recurring operator training cost (contractor): \$15,000–\$25,000 per cohort

Cohorts per year (typical rotation cycle): 2–3

Annual contractor training cost: \$30,000–\$75,000

FFF-402 one-time investment: one cohort, one internal instructor certified.

Internal delivery of all future cohorts at zero recurring contractor cost.

Payback period: typically 1–2 independently-delivered cohorts.

Section 5: Assessment Services Overview

Independent, third-party operator capability evaluation. Three specific use cases for contractor organizations:

1 Contract Acceptance Testing

Third-party verification that delivered platforms can be operated effectively by the receiving unit. Provides defensible documentation for contract closeout.

2

Pre-Hire Screening

Objective 1–5 proficiency ratings across five capability domains. Evaluate candidates on what they can actually do — not what certificates they hold.

3

Readiness Baseline for Training Scope

Assess current capability before scoping the training contract. Prevents over-scoping or under-scoping. Shows the customer you're solving the right problem.

Ready to Build the Proposal?

Tell us your platform, customer organization, and delivery timeline. We scope the training program and return a proposal within 48 hours. SAM registered — standard acquisition vehicles accepted.

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